

The Alhambra

The Red Fortress of Granada (*Qal' at al Hamra* in Arabic) was a mosque, palace and fortified complex, built in stone and timber for the last Muslim emirs in Spain and the Nasrid dynasty. Most of the surviving building was built between c.1333 and 1391 during the time of Muhammad V. Moorish poets described it as 'a pearl set in emeralds', alluding to the colour of its buildings and wooded environs. Built on a mountainous site, it did not follow a strict plan. Surrounded by horseshoe arches, the Court of Lions contains a fountain in an alabaster basin ringed by 12 white marble lions. Water flows from these to the four cardinal compass points. Evoking lightness and grace, the design expresses balance and symmetry, while decorations include geometric shapes, flowers and calligraphy. The Court of the Myrtles, with its long pool and finely columned arcades, leads to the Hall of the Ambassadors, or throne room, containing a vaulted wooden ceiling inlaid with seven tiers of interlacing star-shaped patterns – alluding to the seven heavens mentioned in the Qur'an.

